

World in Brief: Jared Kushner meets Hamas; shipping stalls in Hormuz as truce expires



Photograph: Getty Images

Jared Kushner, Donald Trump's son-in-law and envoy, held talks with **Hamas** leaders in [Egypt](#) in an effort to revive a stalled ceasefire in Gaza. The meeting comes after Israel rejected a 15-point peace plan proposed by America last week. Mr Kushner is set to meet Binyamin Netanyahu, Israel's prime minister, on Monday.

Data showed that shipping traffic through the **Strait of Hormuz** slowed to its lowest level in three months at the weekend. A fragile 60-day truce between America and Iran expires on Monday. Last week America's treasury secretary promised a raft of new sanctions. Mr Trump claimed that "pretty soon I'll be declaring the [Hormuz Strait](#) a territory of the United States."

Mr Trump announced plans to "substantially reduce" joint military exercises with **South Korea**, just before the allies began their annual Ulchi Freedom Shield drills. The eleven-day exercise involves some 18,000 South Korean troops. Mr Trump cited South Korea's lack of involvement in the war against Iran and his "very good relationship" with [Kim Jong Un](#), North Korea's leader.

Andy Burnham, Britain's [prime minister](#), exchanged text messages with someone impersonating Mr Trump's chief of staff,

Susie Wiles, compromising security, *Politico* reported. While officials insist no sensitive information was conveyed, the British embassy reportedly raised concerns with the White House, which declined to comment. Downing Street said it does not comment on “national security matters”.

Taiwan’s president, Lai Ching-te, announced that the cabinet’s budget proposal for next year will include cash handouts of NT\$10,000 (\$314). The plan intends to share the economic gains from the country’s semiconductor industry, which has delivered a major windfall for public coffers. Last week Taiwan’s statistics bureau raised its annual growth forecast to 11.1%, which would be its highest rate in nearly four decades.

Japan’s economy grew by 1.1% on an annualised basis in the second quarter. That was considerably below analysts’ expectations of 2%. High energy prices caused by the Iran war, weak consumer spending and low investment all contributed to the disappointing GDP figures, though the slow growth was partially offset by strong export figures. In the first quarter the growth rate was 1.8%.

Australia began vaccinating around 5,000 **Little Penguins** in the state of Victoria, after one died of a potentially devastating strain of bird flu. Australia is home to hundreds of thousands of the birds, which are the world’s smallest [penguins](#) and a big draw for tourists. Catching and inoculating the creatures will not be straightforward, particularly as they will need two jabs.

Figure of the day: 100, the number of balls faced by each team in, you’ve guessed it, The Hundred, Britain’s aptly named domestic cricket tournament. Read about how it is [transforming the game](#).

US in brief: Todd Blanche declares non-independence



Photograph: Reuters

Todd Blanche refused to lead a Justice Department that is independent of the president. On “Meet the Press” Donald Trump’s newly confirmed **attorney-general** said “no attorney-general should ever pledge that.” His statement reflects the rise of the conservative “unitary executive” theory in which all parts of the executive are subordinate to the president. Mr Blanche said that Mr Trump “will never” ask him to do anything unethical or illegal. But the president has repeatedly leaned on prosecutors to pursue those who have crossed him politically.

Hakeem Jeffries, the leader of the Democrats in the House, avoided committing to a vote on **abolishing Immigration and Customs Enforcement** if the Democrats win the House in the midterm elections in November. Some on the party’s populist left want him to do so. He instead said that “what unites Democrats” is strengthening the border and curbing the agency’s abuses. In general, he said, he does not support the agenda of the Democratic Socialists of America.

The **Democratic National Committee** finalised a **new primary calendar**. South Carolina will vote first in 2028, followed by Nevada, New Hampshire, New Mexico, Michigan and Virginia. The calendar completes a contentious process. South Carolina is

seen as a crucial test of a Democrat's ability to win black votes, and Nevada plays that role for Latinos. But the new calendar means **Iowa** will no longer hold its caucus first, and **New Hampshire** law requires it to hold the first primary; it is unclear how the state's Democrats will proceed.

The head of Centcom, responsible for America's forces in the Middle East, called a visit to the ***USS Abraham Lincoln*** "awe-inspiring". But Admiral Brad Cooper implicitly acknowledged stories of poor morale and mental health on the aircraft-carrier, which has been at sea for over 200 consecutive days: "service at sea for long periods isn't for everyone." Several sailors are reported to have tried to jump overboard.

Shadow boxing on the Korean peninsula



Photograph: AP

On Monday an annual summer event begins. America, South Korea and their allies start their eleven-day Ulchi Freedom Shield exercises—simulating war with North Korea to boost their military preparedness. North Korea will respond with a volley of complaints about this “rehearsal for an aggressive war”, while continuing its own [military build-up](#). In the week leading up to the drills, it conducted its own missile tests.

Both sides insist that this year is different. South Korea and its allies claim that North Korea has learned lessons from aiding Russia in its war in Ukraine. Their exercises will simulate GPS disruption, cyber-attacks and drone attacks. And North Korea claims that its enemies’ drills have a “more serious provocative nature and dangerousness than last year”. Yet on Monday Donald Trump ordered the secretary of war to “substantially reduce” the exercises, based on his “very good relationship” with Kim Jong Un, North Korea’s dictator. Stressing the importance of this year’s drills is SOP. The fellow feeling is new.

America's grid needs new rules for data centres



Photograph: Getty Images

America's electricity grid has spare capacity. It can generate 1,250GW of power, yet peak demand is closer to 750GW. Hundreds of gigawatts are unused—and data centres are hungry for them. Some 1,000GW in “large-load” requests—single sites requesting more than 50MW (about as much as a big factory)—are reportedly queuing to hook up. Not all of these projects are real (many are speculative). But large loads were once rare and rules around them are improvised. Connecting this backlog could take years.

Or maybe not. In June America's grid regulator issued an order to six big grid operators: defend your rules for large loads or write new ones, within 60 days. That deadline is on Monday. The regulator has suggested that operators devise formal processes, that large loads pay extra and that data centres be allowed to hook up quickly only if they power down when the grid reaches capacity. These rules could speed up their “path to power”. But developers face another obstacle: a growing and bitter [backlash](#) from locals.

A vibe check for American consumer spending



Photograph: Getty Images

Investors will get a snapshot of how American consumers are feeling, when Walmart, Target and Home Depot report earnings this week. For the past few quarters big-box executives have fretted about the “[K-shaped](#)” economy, in which high earners benefit from rising asset prices while more numerous low earners are reluctant to spend. This pattern has not yet hurt firms’ sales growth, mostly because rich shoppers’ spending has compensated for caution among poorer ones.

But results this week may show that that has changed. America’s war with Iran has pushed up prices, especially of petrol, hurting the wallets of even prosperous consumers. This could be particularly bad for Home Depot, [a seller of tools](#) and building materials. The firm had posted a 4.8% rise in year-on-year sales for the first quarter of 2026. But when consumers are stressed about the economy, home improvements are among the first things they shelve.

China's androids dream of outsize returns



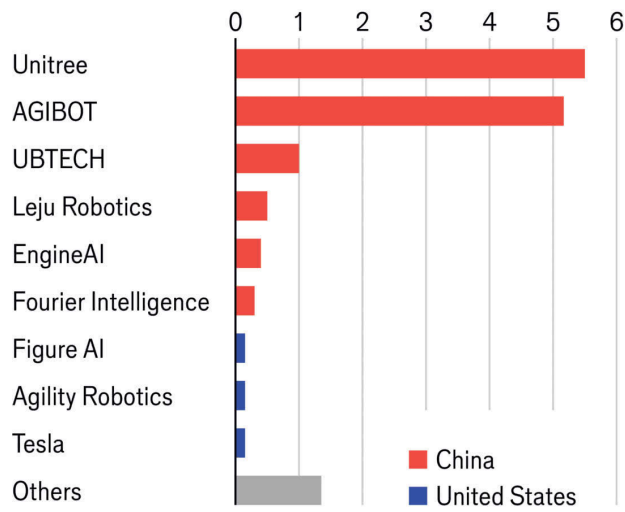
Photograph: Alamy

The IPO of Unitree, a Chinese humanoid-robotics firm, is worth watching for a few reasons. It will be the first maker of human-like droids to go public. The Hangzhou-based company is raising \$900m on Shanghai's bourse rather than in Hong Kong, where Chinese tech firms once preferred to find investors. And the deal appears to have been outrageously over-subscribed.

When Unitree's shares start trading this week, their price will probably shoot skywards, as those of most mainland Chinese IPOs do. But humanoid robotics is in an awkward phase of development. Chinese firms are rushing ahead: more than 14,500 automatons were delivered last year globally, up from around 3,000 in 2024, and almost all [came from China](#). But experts agree it will be years before bots are washing our dishes and taking out the bins. Maintaining a high share price could be tough. Spectacular ascent followed by years of underperformance is also common for Chinese stocks.

Battle of the bots

Global humanoid-robot shipments,
2025 estimate, '000



Sources: Omdia; company reports

Uniqlo's modest ambitions



Photograph: Uniqlo Malaysia

Uniqlo, a big Japanese clothing retailer, launches its first collection of hijabs in Malaysia, Indonesia, Singapore and the Philippines on Monday. The headscarves will be sold in a variety of styles and sweat-wicking fabrics suited to tropical climates. “Modest fashion” is in. [Nike](#) and [Lululemon](#), two North American sportswear brands, have also started selling hijabs.

The clothing companies’ primary market is the world’s billion or so Muslim women, many of whom [dress conservatively](#). Many Muslim countries, such as Indonesia, the world’s biggest, are fast-growing economies. Muslims’ spending on fashion is expected to rise by 6% a year to reach \$444bn in 2029. But modest styles have wider appeal. They suit current trends in many Western countries for oversized fits and longer hemlines, and generally work well for women who want to show less skin. In the fashion industry, less is no longer more.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Which Johnny Cash song was adapted as the title of the 2005 biopic of the country singer?

*A people without the knowledge of
their past history, origin and
culture is like a tree without roots.*

Marcus Garvey